

Do I dare  
Disturb the universe?

T.S. Eliot

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# THE POEM

There is something in my mind called the soul.  
But we've got to beat everyone using only our good looks.

- Chelsey Minnis, *Baby I Don't Care*

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If prose is a house,  
poetry is a man on fire  
running quite fast  
through it.

ANNE CARSON

---

daunting  
difficult  
demanding  
dreary  
distressing  
dreadful  
depressing  
debilitating

# DAVID ORR

“It’s not necessarily helpful to talk about poetry as if it were a device to be assembled or a religious experience to be undergone. Rather, it would be useful to talk about poetry as if it were, for example, Kyrgyzstan.”





# Kyrgyzstan



THE POEM



# ARCHIBALD MCLEISH'S *ARS POETICA* (1926)

A poem should not mean  
But be



# Reading a Poem



THE POEM





All sorts of other questions come into play as well. You find that you are reading for a **voice, tone or texture, for intriguing effects of language**, for the way that the writer does things with words and the way that a text seems to foreground the very experience of reading...



...the question of what reading is and how it works (and perhaps sometimes fails to work), how it **baffles** or **delights**, what it is about (not always obvious) and what it is trying to do to you, what it prompts or even forces you to think about, even if in spite of yourself.



# FRIEDRICH NIETZSCHE'S *CLOSE READING*

One should read 'slowly, deeply, looking cautiously before and aft, with reservations, with doors left open, with delicate eyes and fingers.



# CLEANTH BROOKS' "THE HERESY OF PARAPHRASE"

A poem should not be understood to have a propositional content in the way that, say, this sentence or a newspaper story does.



To try to extract the content or meaning from a poem, to attempt simply to paraphrase it, is a kind of ‘heresy’, a fundamental error, since it is in the very nature of literary texts that what they say is bound up with how they say it.





# WHO?

First, there are questions of voice and authorship: Who is speaking? To what extent are these views the poet's own? Whose voice is this? In what tone or tones are we invited to hear it?



# persona

the poem's speaker or voice



# MEANING

Second, there are the questions of sincerity and intentionality: Does the speaker mean what he says?

What do you want to convey?





ANGELS SINGING IN VOLUMETRIC LIGHTING

insight



THE POEM



# SLANTING IT

Should we be alert for the distinction between what is said and what is meant? In other words, does the poem say one thing and mean another?



# EVERYTHING IS

A poem's insight refers to the deeper understanding, perspective, or revelation that it provides about a specific theme, emotion, or aspect of human experience.



# ILLUMINATED

It often emerges from the way the poet uses language, imagery, rhythm, and metaphor to convey an underlying truth or observation.

This insight may reveal something previously unrecognized or offer a new perspective on familiar topics.



# irony

double negations





# ISN'T IT IRONIC?

Irony happens when there is a contrast between appearance and reality, or between what is said (or unsaid) and what is meant. It is a way for poets to express complex layers of meaning, often by creating discrepancies between the surface narrative and the underlying message.



# **verbal irony**

When a poet says one thing but means another.

It often involves sarcasm or understatement. For example, saying "What a beautiful day!" during a storm.



# situational irony

When there is a stark contrast between what is expected to happen and what actually happens.

For instance, have you seen *And the Breadwinner Is?* in which the protagonist returns home to find everything he knew stayed the same, when he expected to find things to change.





# dramatic irony

When the reader knows something the character or speaker does not.

In poetry, this can create tension or emotional impact because the audience has more insight than the speaker.

In fiction, this is exemplified by the unreliable narrator.



In **The Truman Show**, the main character Truman Burbank lives his entire life unaware that his reality is actually a staged television show. The audience, however, knows the truth about Truman's existence. The dramatic irony creates a unique blend of humor, sympathy, and tension, as we watch Truman unknowingly confront signs that his world is artificial.



# forms

How do technical factors such as the rhyming, alliteration, enjambment and so on participate in the sense?



sonnet  
villanelle  
sestina  
ghazal  
phantom  
free verse



rules to the dance

the meter





## the iambic pentameter

It is close to the human heartbeat and pulse, this connection is both physiological and psychological, making iambic pentameter feel intuitive, rhythmic, and almost musical to the human ear.

A normal resting heart rate is about 60–100 beats per minute, which is roughly the speed at which spoken iambic pentameter is naturally recited.



# MEET THE **IAMB**



unstressed

stressed



Shall I compare thee to a summer's day? (Shakespeare)

(da-DUM da-DUM da-DUM da-DUM da-DUM)

da=systole

DUM=diastole, if we were to follow the heartbeat comparison.





How happy is the blameless vestal's lot!  
The world forgetting, by the world forgot.  
Eternal sunshine of the spotless mind!  
Each prayer accepted, and each wish resigned;

*from "Eloisa to Abelard" by Alexander Pope*



**Breathing & Speech Patterns:** English naturally falls into iambic rhythms in casual speech. Because iambic pentameter aligns with how we breathe and speak, it feels both conversational and elevated.

**Cognitive Comfort:** The predictability of iambic pentameter creates a subconscious sense of ease and expectation, much like a steady pulse calms the body.



**Emotional Impact:** When poets break the rhythm—

using a **trochee** ( ' ~ )

or a **spondee** ( ' ' )

—it disrupts the "heartbeat," creating tension, surprise, or emphasis.

A disrupted meter (e.g., an extra syllable, stress shift) mimics emotional distress, excitement, or urgency.



Example: In Shakespeare's Macbeth, Macbeth's famous line disrupts the iambic flow:

*"Tomorrow, and tomorrow, and tomorrow,"*

The repetition slows the rhythm, reflecting the weariness and inevitability of time.



# (Formal) Elements of a Poem





ARCHITECTURE

stanza

la stanza; room



THE POEM



Rooms in houses have different purposes: you cook in the kitchen, sleep in the bedroom, socialize in the living room, etc. Similarly, stanzas in poetry have different purposes: to disclose a speaker's feelings, a speaker's change of perspective, to provide imagery, etc.



you cross it

the line





enjambment

to enjamb



In formal verse, it is syllable count (haiku), rhyme (ballads), or meter (Petrarchan sonnet) that determines the line length, but in free verse, what determines the line length is more variable.

Poets have different thoughts and aesthetics when it comes to line length. Some poets, like Jorie Graham have a long sense of line during her *Region of Unlikeness* era.



A heart beat, likely the first thing we feel or hear while inside our mothers, is iambic, the ba-boom, is an iambic pattern (unaccented syllable followed by an accented syllable) and is very similar to the lub-dub of a human heart. Patterns of biological sounds are all around us.

Some poets determine their line length based on what can be said in one breath. Others consider a line a unit of thought. A common way of thinking of a line of poetry is as a “unit of attention.” This is the same with enjambments.



# The Red Wheelbarrow

by William Carlos Williams

so much depends  
upon

a red wheel  
barrow

glazed with rain  
water

beside the white  
chickens



**Enjambment** is a poetic device in which a sentence or thought runs over from one line of poetry to the next, without a pause or punctuation at the end of the first line. This technique creates a sense of continuation, urgency, or fluidity, as the reader must move into the next line to complete the meaning.

Enjambment contrasts with **end-stopped lines**, where the line ends with punctuation, completing the thought or sentence.





- Increase pace: It encourages the reader to move quickly through the poem.
- Create suspense or surprise: The reader doesn't get the full meaning until the next line. Double meaning is also encouraged through suspension of line cut.
- Enhance rhythm: It can work with the poem's meter to create a more dynamic, fluid movement.



Tell me it was for the hunger  
& nothing less. For hunger is to give  
the body what it knows

it cannot keep. That this amber light  
whittled down by another war  
is all that pins my hand

to your chest.

from “On Earth We’re Briefly Gorgeous” by Ocean Vuong



not back, let's not come back, let's go by the speed of  
queer zest & stay up  
there & get ourselves a little  
moon cottage (so pretty), then start a moon garden  
  
with lots of moon veggies (so healthy), i mean  
i was already moonlighting  
as an online moonologist  
most weekends, so this is the immensely





logical next step, are you  
packing your bags yet, don't forget your  
sailor moon jean jacket, let's wear  
our sailor moon jean jackets while twirling in that lighter,

queerer moon gravity, let's love each other  
(so good) on the moon, let's love  
the moon  
on the moon

“i love you to the moon &” by Chen Chen



the imagination trigger

the image



so many poems about the rain

# objective correlative



This originated from T.S. Eliot in his essay **Hamlet and His Problems**.

He argued that emotions in literature should be expressed through a pattern of objects or events that act as a kind of formula for evoking a particular feeling.



**Objective correlative** is a literary technique in which an external set of objects, situations, or events is used to evoke a specific emotion in the reader, rather than directly stating that emotion. The idea is that emotions are best conveyed through concrete imagery and actions rather than abstract descriptions.





## Examples

The Videotapes in **The Ring** (2002) – The cursed videotape serves as a physical manifestation of trauma, grief, and the way pain is passed from one person to another.

The Chair in **Get Out** (2017) – The chair that Chris is strapped to, and the cotton he pulls from it, represents both oppression and survival, linking to the history of slavery and resistance.



## Examples

The House in **Bojack Horseman** – Bojack's empty mansion serves as a visual representation of his loneliness, regret, and inability to find fulfillment despite his success.

The Christmas Lights in **Stranger Things** (Season 1) – Represent Joyce's desperation and belief in her son's survival, as well as the bridge between worlds.



## Examples

The Kitchen's Chaos in **The Bear**– A metaphor for Carmy's mental state, as his personal and professional struggles collide.

Ellie's Joke Book in **The Last of Us** – A small, lighthearted object that represents her innocence and how she clings to joy despite the world's brutality.





NOT TO CONFUSE WITH

pathetic  
fallacy



THE POEM



**Pathetic fallacy** is a literary device in which human emotions, thoughts, or sensations are attributed to nature, inanimate objects, or the environment.

The term was coined by John Ruskin in the 19th century, and while he originally used it to criticize what he saw as overly sentimental descriptions of nature, today it is widely recognized as a powerful poetic technique.



By aligning natural elements with human feelings, poets create deeper emotional resonance and symbolic meaning.

- A storm mirroring a character's inner turmoil.
- A calm sea representing peace or contentment.
- Falling leaves symbolizing sadness or decay.



At the end of my suffering  
there was a door.  
Hear me out: that which you call death  
I remember.

from “The Wild Iris” by Louise Glück



The night is darkening round me,  
The wild winds coldly blow."

from "Wuthering Heights" by Emily Brontë





A host, of golden daffodils;  
Beside the lake, beneath the trees,  
Fluttering and dancing in the breeze."

from "I Wandered Lonely as a Cloud" by William Wordsworth



| Feature                | Pathetic Fallacy                                 | Objective Correlative                                                |
|------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Emotion Representation | Assigns human emotions to nature or objects      | Uses a set of objects or events to evoke emotion                     |
| Technique              | Personification (e.g., "angry storm")            | Symbolism & association (e.g., "withered leaves on an empty street") |
| Effect                 | Creates mood through direct emotional projection | Indirectly makes the audience experience an emotion                  |
| Example Writers        | William Wordsworth, Emily Brontë, Shakespeare    | T.S. Eliot, Ezra Pound, James Joyce                                  |



the physical world = erotic

the senses





# visual imagery (sight)



I'd have to be really quick  
to describe clouds –  
a split second's enough  
for them to start being something else.

from "Clouds" by Wisława Szymborska



# auditory imagery & musicality (sound)



"Open here I flung the shutter, when, with many a flirt and flutter,  
In there stepped a stately Raven of the saintly days of yore;  
Not the least obeisance made he; not a minute stopped or stayed he;  
But, with mien of lord or lady, perched above my chamber door—  
Perched upon a bust of Pallas just above my chamber door—  
Perched, and sat, and nothing more."

from "The Raven" by Edgar Allan Poe



# tactile imagery (touch)





The heart is the toughest part of the body.  
Tenderness is in the hands.

from “The Country Between” by Carolyn Forché



THE POEM



# gustatory imagery (taste)



"I have eaten  
the plums  
that were in  
the icebox  
and which  
you were probably  
saving  
for breakfast  
Forgive me  
they were delicious  
so sweet  
and so cold."

from "This is Just To Say" by William Carlos Williams





# olfactory imagery (smell)



The whiskey on your breath  
Could make a small boy dizzy;  
But I hung on like death:  
Such waltzing was not easy.

from “My Papa’s Waltz” by Theodroe Roethke



emotional  
& psychological impact  
(synesthesia)



"That was the summer she wore the blue dress,  
the one that made a sound like the sea  
as she walked..."

from "The Blue Dress" by Sharon Olds



"Hello, sun in my face.  
Hello, you who make the morning light  
so sugary and full of milk."

from "Why I Wake Up Early" by Mary Oliver





"I watch your shadow  
filling the room with silence."

from "Bright Star" by Carol Ann Duffy



FIGURATIVELY!

metaphor



THE POEM



# NOT TO BE CONFUSED WITH SIMILE

If the sentence says something *is* something else → Metaphor

If the sentence compares something to something else using "*like*" or "*as*" → Simile





| Feature    | Metaphor                                                                            | Simile                                                           |
|------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Definition | A direct comparison between two unrelated things, stating that one is the other.    | A comparison between two things using like or as.                |
| Key Words  | No comparison words (is, are, was, were often used).                                | Uses like, as, resembles, similar to.                            |
| Example    | "Her smile is sunshine."                                                            | "Her smile is like sunshine."                                    |
| Effect     | Stronger, more direct comparison; creates deeper symbolic meaning.                  | Lighter, more explicit comparison; emphasizes similarity.        |
| Usage      | Often used in poetry and literature to create strong imagery and abstract meanings. | Common in everyday language and poetry to clarify a resemblance. |

Metaphor is a completely natural linguistic phenomenon.

It comes naturally to humans. Our cultures create and spread them without our having to think about doing so at all.

Poets take advantage of this instinct by creating new metaphors, ones that are not common or familiar,  
**to defamiliarize.**



Tenor  
(Subject)

Vehicle  
(Comparison)

# time is a thief

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*Ground*

*(The connection between tenor and vehicle)*

*~Time steals moments.~*



All the world's a stage,  
and all the men and  
women merely players.

SHAKESPEARE



The stars are the same  
as they were before you were born

OCEAN VUONG





The body is the first country

JERICHO BROWN



THE POEM



The sky is a sieve, and I am the rain

RICHARD SIKEN



THE POEM



# First Fig

My candle burns at both ends;  
It will not last the night;  
But ah, my foes, and oh, my friends—  
It gives a lovely light!

EDNA ST. VINCENT MILLAY





THERE BE DRAGONS

the unknown



THE POEM



**Negative capability** is a term coined by the poet John Keats in 1817 to describe a writer's ability to embrace uncertainty, ambiguity, and mystery without needing to resolve them. In poetry, this means allowing contradictions and open-ended ideas to exist rather than forcing logic or clear-cut conclusions.



Keats described negative capability as:

"when a man is capable of being in uncertainties,  
Mysteries, doubts, without any irritable reaching after fact  
and reason."

He contrasted this with writers who try too hard to impose  
order or rationality on everything. Instead, Keats valued  
intuition, emotion, and the beauty of the unknown in  
poetry.



**Negative capability** makes poetry richer and more thought-provoking because it resists easy explanations. It allows readers to experience emotion, imagery, and uncertainty without being told what to think.

It reflects real-life uncertainty, mirroring emotions and experiences in a way that definitive answers cannot.



## **Shadow of the Colossus** (2005)

Ends on a mysterious, cyclical note, leaving the meaning of the protagonist's transformation open to interpretation.

## **Inside** (2016)

The game's surreal, wordless storytelling refuses to provide clear explanations, forcing players to piece together meaning.

## **The Legend of Zelda: Majora's Mask** (2000)

The game's themes of death, time, and identity are left largely unexplained, leading to endless fan interpretations.





## **The Sopranos** (1999-2007)

The infamous cut-to-black ending leaves Tony Soprano's fate unresolved, forcing the audience to live with the ambiguity.

## **The Leftovers** (2014-2017)

The series never explains the Sudden Departure (the disappearance of 2% of the world's population), focusing instead on the emotional weight of uncertainty.

## **Dark** (2017-2020)

The show thrives on paradoxes and contradictions, especially in its time-travel logic, leaving some questions intentionally unanswered.



STRANGEWAYS, HERE WE COME!

to make it strange



LOVE - hearts, a loved one's face  
DEATH - coffin, grave, tombstone  
SELF - mirror, photo, conehead  
SOUL - votive fire, blinding light, god's eye





Self - spoiled head of cabbage



1

Rage  
Order  
Justice  
Common

2

Solitude  
Ecstasy  
Evil  
Gratitude

3

Mercy  
Pain  
Hunger  
God

4

Love  
Infidelity  
Sexism  
Racism



THERE'S MORE TO LIFE THAN BOOKS,  
YOU KNOW  
BUT NOT MUCH MORE

MORRISSEY



FIN.

# Kill your darlings.



FIN.